English Language Practice Workbook

PAPER 1 READING · INSERTS

20 Inserts (reading passages for each paper)

Cambridge O Level English Language 1123 format · Time allowed: 2 hours each

Preview

Prepared by PaperBros

Original practice material in the format of Cambridge O Level English Language 1123. Not an official Cambridge publication.

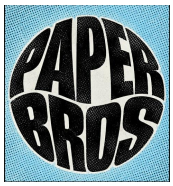
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Practice Paper Series

O Level Practice Paper

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/01**

Paper 1 Reading **Practice Paper 01**

INSERT **2 hours**

INFORMATION

- This insert contains the reading passages.
- You may annotate this insert and use the blank spaces for planning. **Do not write your answers** on the insert.

Preview

This document has 4 pages. Any blank pages are indicated.

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[Turn over

PREVIEW

Read Text A, then answer Question 1 and Question 2 on the question paper.

Text A: The boat race

In this text, the writer remembers the year he rowed in his village's boat race.

Every autumn, when the rains had finally exhausted themselves and the river lay wide, brown and lazy beside our village, the whole of Charpara began to talk about only one thing: the boat race. For three days in October, long, narrow boats painted red, green and yellow would sweep past the banks while drummers beat out a rhythm for the rowers. My grandfather, whom everyone called Dadu, had won the race seven times as a young man. His oar still hung above the door of our house, its blade cracked and its handle worn smooth and dark by his hands, and visitors would point at it before they had even taken off their sandals.

Dadu was not a man who smiled easily. He woke before the call to prayer, walked the length of the riverbank every morning with his hands clasped behind his back, and spoke to me mostly in instructions: sit straight, eat properly, stop wasting the daylight. When I was small, I was secretly terrified of him. He had a way of looking at me over the top of his spectacles that made me feel as though he could see every lie I had ever told. My cousins, who lived in Dhaka and visited only at Eid, thought he was wonderful because he slipped them sweets. They never had to live with him.

The summer I turned thirteen, the captain of our village boat, a fisherman called Rafiq Bhai, came to our yard and asked Dadu if I could take the place of a rower who had broken his wrist. I expected Dadu to laugh. Instead, he looked at my thin arms for a long time, then nodded once. 'He will be ready,' he said, as if it had already been decided, and walked back into the house. I stood in the yard with my mouth open, not knowing whether to feel honoured or condemned.

Training began the next morning. Every day before school, Dadu took me down to the river in his old wooden dinghy and made me row against the current until my palms blistered and my shoulders burned. He did not shout; he simply said 'Again' every time I stopped, until the word seemed to echo inside my skull. In the evenings, my mother rubbed mustard oil into my aching arms and muttered that the old man would kill me before the race did. I said nothing, but at night I lay awake listening to the frogs and wondering why I had ever agreed.

Slowly, though, something changed. By the third week my blisters had hardened into calluses, and I could row to the bend in the river without stopping. One morning, as the mist lifted off the water, Dadu leaned forward and corrected the angle of my wrists with his own rough fingers. 'The river is not your enemy,' he said quietly. 'Listen to it.' It was the longest speech he had ever made to me, and I carried it around all day like a coin in my pocket.

On the morning of the race, the banks were crowded with people from six villages. Children had climbed into the branches of the banyan trees; women held umbrellas against the sun; men stood ankle-deep in the mud, shouting advice that no one could hear. Our boat, the Shapla, was forty metres long and so narrow that I had to sit with my

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PREVIEW

knees almost touching the back of the rower in front of me. My hands were slippery with sweat before I had even touched the oar, and I could not remember a single thing I had been taught. I glanced at the bank and saw Dadu standing apart from the crowd, perfectly still, his white kurta bright against the green rice fields. My stomach turned over like a fish in a net.

Then the drum began. Twenty-five oars struck the water at once and the Shapla leapt forward like an arrow released from a bow. For the first few minutes I could think of nothing but the rhythm: dip, pull, lift; dip, pull, lift. Spray stung my eyes. The boat from Kalinagar drew level with us, its rowers grunting, their faces twisted with effort, and for one terrible moment their bow crept ahead of ours. My arms were screaming. I wanted to stop, just for a second, just to breathe.

But then, beneath the roar of the crowd, I heard it – or imagined I heard it – the quiet voice from those misty mornings: listen to it. I stopped fighting the water and let my oar slip into it as though the river itself were pulling me along. Our drummer, sensing the change, quickened the beat. The Shapla surged, gliding past Kalinagar inch by inch, until the finishing flag flashed by overhead and the banks exploded into a storm of cheering, whistling and drumming.

Later, soaked and shaking, I climbed the muddy bank to find Dadu. He did not hug me. He simply placed his hand on my shoulder, heavy and warm, and left it there for a long moment. ‘Seven times I won,’ he said at last. ‘But I never once rowed as well as you did today.’ That evening, when I came home, I found that the oar I had used that day had been hung above the door, beside his.

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